

My final project was inspired by the conversations I had with inmates during our visit to Matsqui Institution. Two of the inmates I met spoke fondly of the women in their lives, and the impact it had on their rehabilitation. The dominant theme of these conversations was the way their love lives inspired self-improvement.

For Mr. Makichuk, a desire to be on parole and with his wife motivated continued progress on his correctional plan. Day parole visits and time with his wife were obvious highlights of his life. During my visit with him, I was spellbound listening to the most remarkable story of rehabilitation I had ever heard. Evidently, his relationship with his wife had helped him along his journey from one of the most dangerous inmates in Canada, to someone who may be soon released on parole.

Another inmate I spoke to told me about a girlfriend he met while on parole. To him, she was the love of his life. One night, they were sleeping and he woke up to find her dead. She had died of a blood clot in her sleep. This sent him in a downward spiral, and he eventually wound up back in prison. After he was able to recover from some of his grief, he chose to honour her memory by pursuing first aid training. He wanted to ensure that he never felt the sense of helplessness he did during her death. While his story is distinct from Mr. Makichuk's, the theme is the same: love driving someone to be the best version of themselves.

While many different factors can land someone in prison, it was clear to me that the experience of giving and receiving love was a powerful motivator for self-

improvement. Deprivation of liberty inevitably impacts one's self worth. Love is a formidable factor that can restore one's sense of dignity and humanity.

Accordingly, my art project reflects this theme. I drew further inspiration from the website, Canadian Inmates Connect. It is a website dedicated to inmates serving federal sentences in institutions in Canada. Inmates can post profiles through the website's administration, and members of the public can write to them. Some inmates seek friendship, and others relationships. The website is open to both female and male inmates. The testimonial of one inmate posted on the site is illustrative:

I was in the S.H.U. as one of the most violent, dangerous criminals in Canada without hope or vision. Now all I think about is getting out. Your website has changed my life in only ways that I can understand. I'm on a totally different path and I'm grateful for everything. I'm sure I'm not the only one. I'm not sure if you really understand the affect your website has on people, lots of people. Not just for the people in prison but also showing people on the outside a different understanding of a dark world where some good people made mistakes and now we are lost looking to find ourselves and that's what you've really helped me to do. For my entire life I was on a path to pain and death. Now I feel love and life. I feel alive. I feel.

Other testimonials speak about the impact of human contact on their individual growth. For some, it is valuable to meet someone outside of a criminal lifestyle, which helps to aid their rehabilitation when they eventually get released.

With this background, my project is structured as follows. First, I divided the canvas into 9 squares. Three squares have a large red heart on them. Within it, I transcribed excerpts from inmate biographies posted on Canadian Inmates Connect. Second, there are three photographs of inmates, which they posted on the site. And third, I selected some of the sentences that the inmates received to paste into the yellow squares.

The separation is intentional. I wanted to show the division of the institutional self, the desires and hopes of the inmates and the way in which they

chose to represent themselves. In this way, I provoke the reader to consider different sides of the prisoner. The red squares are written in a cursive, flowing font to represent the softer, loving side. The yellow squares are meant to be more harsh, the institutional branding of the inmate and their sentence, in bolder more traditional font. The blue/purple squares represent the inmate themselves. In all the photos they are portraying a tough image of themselves. I chose to overlap the pictures with purple bars to represent the intersect between the tough and the soft sides of the inmates.

In conclusion, the aim of my project was to consider an element that was impactful for me during the term – the relationships that inmates I met had and the impact on their lives. In this way, I wanted to reflect broader themes of dignity, self worth and rehabilitation.